

Helpful robots

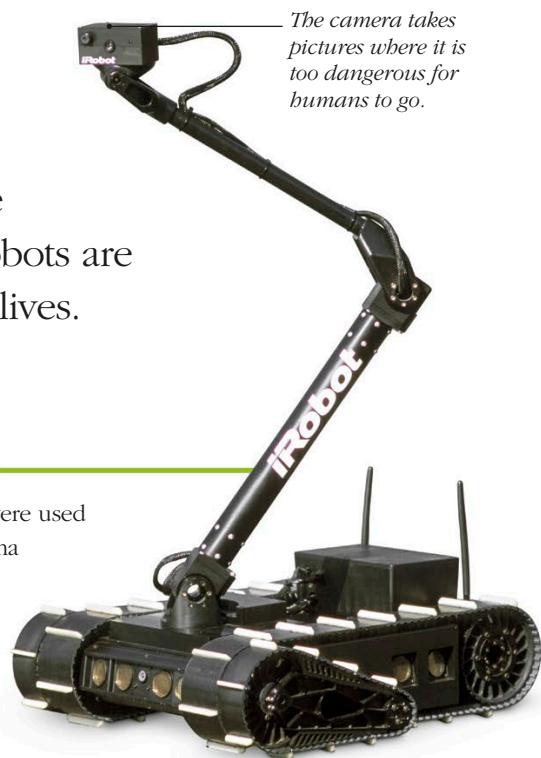
In 1920, the Czech writer Karel Capek staged a play that introduced the world to the word “robot.” The story ends with the robots taking over from the humans. Since then, there have been continued fears about where artificial intelligence might lead us. In reality, however, robots are mostly developed to help us in almost every area of our lives.

Search robots

- **What?** PackBot
- **Who?** iRobot
- **Where and when?** US, 1998

The PackBot is a series of military robots. They have a robotic arm and camera and are mainly used for exploration—checking

buildings for explosives, for example. They were used in Japan to measure radiation at the Fukushima Daiichi Nuclear Power Plant after it was destroyed in an earthquake in 2011, and to search the World Trade Center in New York City after the 2001 terrorist attacks.

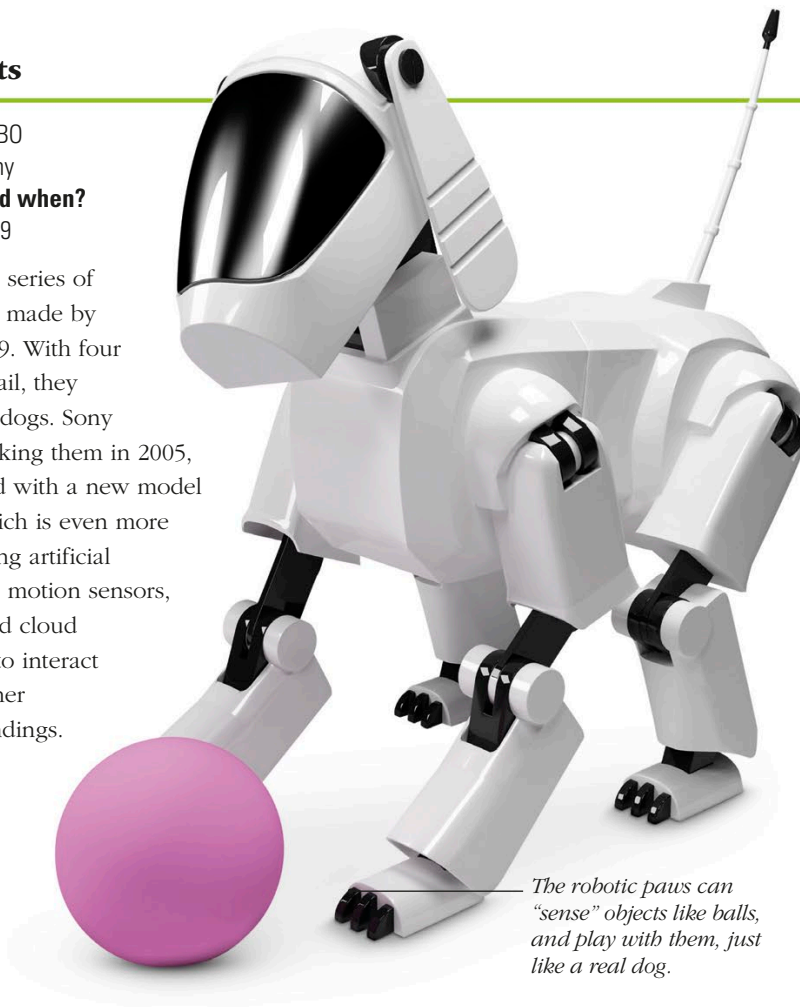


The camera takes pictures where it is too dangerous for humans to go.

Robo-pets

- **What?** AIBO
- **Who?** Sony
- **Where and when?** Japan, 1999

AIBO was a series of robotic pets made by Sony in 1999. With four legs and a tail, they looked like dogs. Sony stopped making them in 2005, but resumed with a new model in 2018, which is even more doglike, using artificial intelligence, motion sensors, cameras, and cloud computing to interact with its owner and surroundings.

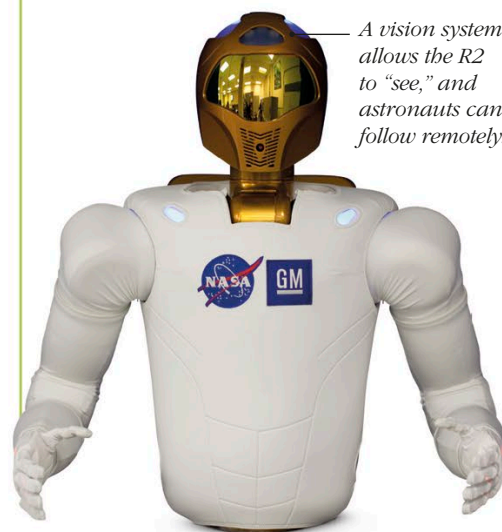


The robotic paws can “sense” objects like balls, and play with them, just like a real dog.

Robo-astronauts

- **What?** Robonaut 2 (R2)
- **Who?** NASA
- **Where and when?** US, 2010

NASA developed Robonaut to work alongside astronauts on manned space missions. The latest version, R2, is designed to have tasks programmed and then carry them out without any human supervision. In February 2011, R2 was sent to work on the International Space Station.



A vision system allows the R2 to “see,” and astronauts can follow remotely.